What is Solana?

Anna wants to send 10 dollars to her friend Boris. This page follows that money the whole way, and by the end you will know what Solana is and why anybody bothers with it. Nothing to buy, nothing to install, about six minutes.

1 Your money is a line in a list

Start with Anna, who has money in a bank. The bank does not keep her notes in a box with her name on it. What it keeps is a list, and one line on that list says how much is hers.

So when Anna pays Boris, no notes travel anywhere. The bank simply changes two lines, and hers gets smaller while his gets bigger. That is the whole of it.

THE BANK'S LIST

Anna	$100
Boris	$20

Anna pays Boris 10 dollars, so two numbers change and nothing else in the world moves.

2 The list belongs to the bank

That payment worked, and Anna never thought about it again. Then her cousin abroad needed money on a Sunday evening, and suddenly the list had opinions. It is one list with one owner, which means the bank makes all the rules about it.

It picks who may have a line at all, it sets the price of every change, and it shuts at night. Anna waited until Monday.

One copy sitting behind one door, and that door can close.

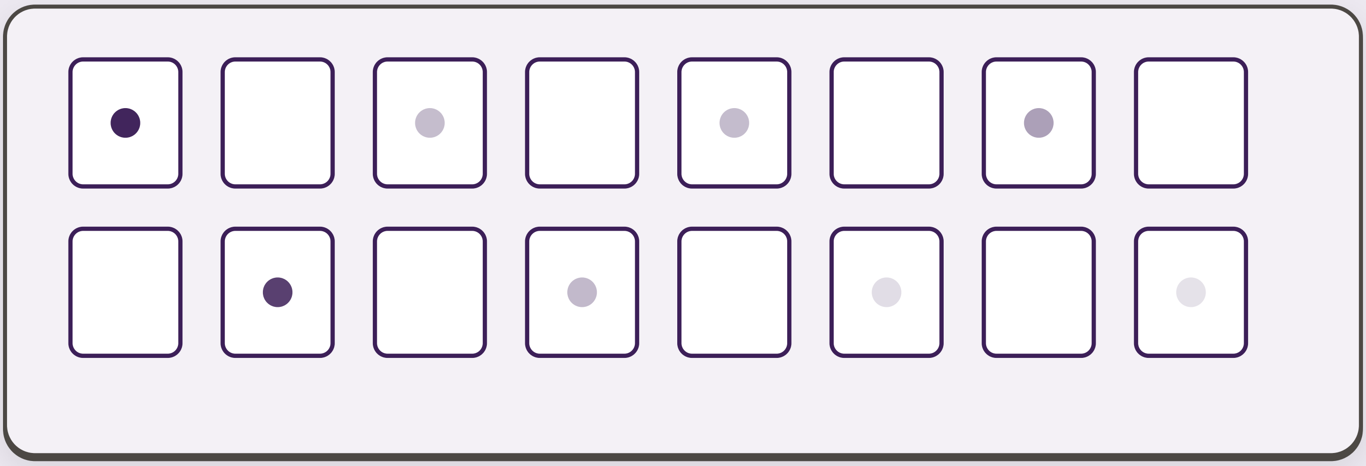
Is that a bad thing?

Usually not, since most of the world runs this way and it works fine. You only feel it on a Sunday, or on the day somebody says no to you and there is nowhere else to go.

3 Solana is the same list, on many computers

So here is the question somebody asked years ago: what if the list were not kept by one bank at all? That is Solana. It is the same kind of list, except that it does not live in any one place.

Hundreds of computers hold it at the same time, each with its own copy, and they spend all day checking each other.



Point at any one copy, and watch what all the others do.

690

separate computers were keeping this list when this file was made, on 12 August 2026. On the live page your own browser counts them again.

4 Nobody is the boss

Which raises the obvious worry. If nobody owns the list, what stops one of those computers writing whatever it likes? No single computer can change the list on its own, because they all have to agree first.

Nobody asks permission to join, and nobody can rub out a line that is already written.

WHO GETS A SAY

18 computers	the other 672 computers
one third of the vote	two thirds of the vote

Hundreds of owners, with a few big ones among them, and both halves of that are true.

Why do 18 computers matter more than 672?

To take part, a computer has to lock some of its own money into the list first, where everyone can see it. That money is paid to nobody, and it comes back if the owner stops taking part. It sits there as a deposit, and the bigger the deposit, the more that computer's vote counts. So they are not equal at all.

The biggest one has about 4 votes in every 100, and the 18 biggest add up to a third of all the votes. Since a new line needs more than two thirds to agree, those 18 can block one between them.

The list is spread out, and it is spread out unevenly. Anyone who tells you only the first half of that is selling you something.

5 It is fast

Fine, says Anna, but her cousin is still waiting. How long does this one take? Solana adds a page to the list about twice a second, which is quicker than you can blink.

Bitcoin was the first list of this kind, back in 2009, and it aims at one page every ten minutes. Watch the two of them running side by side.

BITCOIN, live too

waiting 36:28 since its last page

SOLANA, live, on your screen

Both bars are real, and Solana fills its own while Bitcoin is still waiting for a single page.

On the live page these two bars race each other.

The Solana bar runs at the real speed measured above, while the bank bar stands for one working day, squeezed into thirty seconds so you do not have to sit and wait for it.

0.41s

is the gap between one page of the list and the next, timed over 200 pages in a row on 12 August 2026. On the live page it is timed again while you read.

Why is Bitcoin sometimes stuck at twenty minutes?

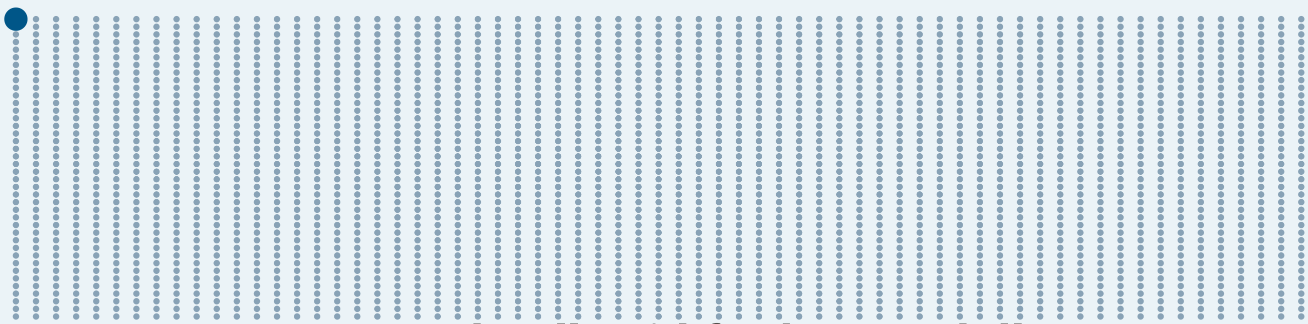
Ten minutes is what Bitcoin aims at on average, but it is not a promise, and the real gaps wander a lot. Checked while this page was built, the last nine ran from six seconds to twenty-four minutes.

The bar above shows the true wait since Bitcoin wrote its last page, so if it sits on twenty minutes, that is simply Bitcoin taking its time and the page is fine.

6 It costs almost nothing

The next thing Anna wants to know is the price. The network takes its fee in a coin of its own, called SOL. One send costs 0.000005 of that coin, which today is about four hundredths of one US cent.

One dollar pays for roughly 2,600 sends, and every dot below is one of them. Point at the picture if you want a closer look.



2,600 sends, all paid for by one dollar

Your bank would charge you more than this just to print a statement.

On the live page a slider prices any amount you choose. Here it stands at

$100

Solana takes	**$0.00038**
A card would take, at the 2.9% plus 30 cents Stripe publishes	**$3.20**
You keep this much more	**$3.20**

Worked out at $75.82 per SOL, the price this page just read from Coinbase.

7 It never sleeps

And that Sunday evening which started all this? There are no opening hours here, and no holidays either.

Three in the morning on a Sunday works exactly the same as Tuesday lunchtime.

537,366,386,816

lines written into this list since the very first day, counted on 12 August 2026. On the live page the number climbs while you read.

8 Now the careful part

By now it sounds too good, so here is the other half, which is the half most explanations leave out.

! **The price jumps about**

That coin, SOL, is also something people buy and hold, and its price has fallen by more than half inside a single year, more than once. This is nothing like a savings account.

! **Lose your key, lose the money**

There is nobody to ring and no password to reset, and that is the price of having nobody in charge.

! **Nothing can be undone**

Send it to the wrong person and it stays sent, and anyone at all can use this list, including people who lie for a living.

! **It has stopped before**

The whole thing halted for about seventeen hours in September 2021, and again for about five hours in February 2024, and both times people had to agree on a restart by hand.

9 Look at real payments

Anna and Boris are made up, but the payments below are not. Each one landed on the real list seconds ago, sent by somebody you will never meet.

On the live page a button opens the newest page of the list and shows the plain payments written on it, with a receipt in ordinary words. One example, read while this file was made: somebody sent 0.0100 SOL, about 77 cents, and it cost them 0.00038 of a dollar. The page it came from held 1,486 entries and had been written four seconds earlier.

Now follow that money one step further

Every payment above went somewhere. In a bank you can see your own balance and nobody else's. Your neighbour's is hidden from you, and so is everybody else's. Here you can look inside the pocket the money landed in, and nobody can stop you.

10 Did any of it stick?

One last thing, and then Anna leaves you alone. Four questions, with nothing scored and nothing sent anywhere.

Where are your 100 dollars when people say they are "in the bank"?

- In a box with your name on it
- It is a line in the bank's list
- Turned into gold in a vault

A payment just changes two lines in that list, and Solana works the same way, except the list is kept by many computers at once.

Who can stop you from having a line in Solana's list?

- A bank manager
- The government of your country
- Nobody

There is no application to fill in and no approval to wait for, which cuts both ways, and that is why part 8 exists.

Do all the computers that keep the list count the same as each other?

- Yes, one computer one vote
- No, each one counts as much as the money it has put down

Today the largest one holds about 4 percent of the say, and the 18 largest can block a decision between them.

If you forget the key to your account, who can get your money back for you?

- Customer support
- Your bank
- Nobody at all

This is the real cost of having nobody in charge, and it is the same fact as the last answer, only seen from the other side.

WHERE EVERY NUMBER HERE COMES FROM

The live figures are read from a public Solana computer while your browser is open, and none of them is typed in by hand. If that computer cannot be reached, the page falls back to the values below, all measured on 12 August 2026.

WHAT WAS MEASURED	ANSWER
Seconds between pages, timed over 200 pages in a row	0.41 s
Cost of one send	0.000005 SOL
That cost in dollars, at 76.24 USD per SOL	$0.00038
Computers keeping the list	690 machines
Share held by the single biggest one	3.91%
Computers whose deposits together pass one third	18 machines

The two-thirds rule in part 4 is the one running on the network today. Solana is preparing a new voting system, called Alpenglow, which replaces it with thresholds of 60 and 80 percent. That change has not landed yet: of the 3,804 computers reachable on 12 August 2026, 36 were running a version new enough to carry it. Anything you read that states the new numbers as current is ahead of the network.

The fee rule and the voting threshold are published by the network itself, at solana.com/docs/core/fees and docs.anza.xyz. Bitcoin's ten minutes is the value sitting in Bitcoin's own source code today. The two outage lengths come from the reports the Solana Foundation published at the time. Everything else was measured against the public node api.mainnet-beta.solana.com on the day shown, and the SOL price was taken from Coinbase and checked against Kraken the same day.